The Government of India pursues a three dimensional strategy for development of women, namely ***social empowerment, economic empowerment*** and ***gender justice*** which is to be continued with in the 12th Plan, too.[9] The government has started several schemes and initiated many new policy initiatives for the welfare and development of women and children which also include initiatives for economic and social empowerment of women and securing gender equality in various aspects of social, economic, and political life. The scope and coverage of the schemes for women and child development have been expanding under various Plans.

Women lag behind men in many social indicators like health, education and economic opportunities. Hence they need special attention due to their vulnerability and lack of access to resources. Since national budgets impact men and women differently through the pattern of resource allocation, the scope and coverage of schemes for women and child development have been expanded with progressive increase in Plan expenditure under various Plan schemes, increased employment for women under the MGNREGA and *gender budgeting* (GB).[10] The allocations for GB as a percentage of total budget have gone up from **2.79** per cent in 2005-06 to **5.91** per cent in 2012-13. Some of the important schemes and policy initiatives for economic and social empowerment of women and child development are as follows –

Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) Scheme

The *objective* of the ICDS scheme is holistic development of children below 6 years of age and proper nutrition and health education of pregnant and lactating mothers starting with 33 projects and 4891 anganwadi centres (AWCs) in 1975.

This has now been *universalized* with cumulative approval of 7076 projects and 14 lakh AWCs including 20,000 anganwadis ‘on-demand’. A proposal for strengthening and restructuring of the ICDS Scheme (with an overall budget allocation of Rs. 1,23,580 crore) during the Twelfth Plan has been approved. Greater emphasis is being laid on awareness generation, *convergence* with the MGNREGA, and MIS-based monitoring.